

For the President
20 July 2026

US Presses Ninth Night of Strikes on Iran as Tehran Retaliates Across the Gulf

We assess that the US-Iran conflict is escalating rather than stabilizing. US Central Command began a ninth consecutive night of strikes at about 7:00 p.m. Eastern on 19 July, aimed at degrading Iran's ability to threaten shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, and Tehran answered with fresh missile and drone attacks against targets in neighboring states. Both sides are now trading blows faster than either is signaling an off-ramp, and we judge the near-term risk is a widening of the target set to Gulf energy and desalination infrastructure.

- Overnight US strikes concentrated on Iranian air and coastal defenses and missile and drone storage, the capabilities most directly tied to Iran's ability to interdict the strait; press reporting and CENTCOM statements corroborate the focus.
- Iran struck US-associated sites in Kuwait — including an ammunition depot at Al-Adiri camp and a Patriot radar at Ali al-Salem air base — and hit a Kuwaiti water-desalination and power facility, which Kuwait's foreign ministry condemned as a strike on civilian infrastructure.
- Four Iranian ballistic missiles were fired toward Aqaba, Jordan; three were intercepted by US air defenses and one struck open ground. Reporting also indicates Iranian fires against Bahrain and Saudi Arabia over the same window.
- US casualties are mounting: a third American service member was killed in recent fighting, bringing US deaths in the conflict to 17. Iranian authorities claim more than 50 killed and over 500 wounded in this month's US strikes — figures we treat as reported, not confirmed.
- Overhead imagery shows Iranian coastal-defense and missile units repositioning after successive nights of US strikes, consistent with an effort to preserve launchers rather than stand down.

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For Washington, the pivotal variable is the Strait of Hormuz. Transit traffic has slowed to its lowest level in three weeks, and Brent crude for September delivery rose about 2.5% to top \$90 a barrel, with WTI near \$84. We assess a sustained closure or a mass-casualty strike on a Gulf state would be the most likely trigger for a larger US commitment; absent that, the campaign probably continues as a punitive, capability-degrading effort. On the nuclear file, the IAEA has been unable to conduct verification inside Iran since late February and cannot confirm the current status of enrichment sites, though it continues to watch Natanz and Fordow via commercial imagery. We expect the next decision point is whether Tehran attempts to actually close the strait — the step that would convert a costly standoff into a global energy shock.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, NGA, CENTCOM, and open sources.

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Burnham To Take Office as UK Prime Minister, Ending the Starmer Government

We assess the United Kingdom is changing prime ministers today with minimal policy disruption to US interests in the near term, but with real uncertainty over the medium term. Keir Starmer is tendering his resignation to King Charles III, who will invite Andy Burnham — confirmed Labour leader on 17 July after the party's leadership contest — to form a government. Because this is an intra-party transition rather than a general election, Labour retains its Commons majority and Britain's core commitments carry over intact for now.

- Continuity is likely on the pillars Washington cares about most — NATO, AUKUS, intelligence sharing, and support for Ukraine — none of which Burnham has signaled an intent to unwind.
- The watch items are fiscal and political: Burnham built his campaign on a more redistributive, spend-oriented platform, and UK gilt yields moved on the leadership turmoil. Pressure on the defense budget and on the pace of the 3.5%-of-GDP NATO trajectory is the most plausible point of divergence from US preferences.
- Burnham enters without his own Commons seat and with a party that just deposed a sitting prime minister, a weak footing that we assess will constrain his room for bold foreign-policy moves early on.

For Washington, the practical near-term task is relationship-building with a leader the administration has not worked with closely. We expect early signals — Burnham's first calls, his line on Ukraine funding, and whether he reaffirms AUKUS timelines — to tell us quickly whether the US-UK relationship holds its current shape.

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Russia Mounts Its Largest Ballistic Barrage on Kyiv of the War

We assess Russia's overnight strike on Kyiv — which Ukrainian officials call the largest ballistic missile attack on the capital since the 2022 invasion — is intended to exhaust Ukraine's dwindling high-end air defenses rather than to seize battlefield advantage. Moscow fired roughly 41 ballistic missiles, including about 10 Zircon hypersonic weapons, alongside 125 drones, with most aimed at Kyiv; at least one person was killed and 17 injured.

- Ukrainian forces reported downing nearly half the ballistic missiles and 108 of 125 drones — a credible intercept rate that nonetheless leaves the leakers doing real damage, including a metro entrance and residential and industrial sites.
- The concentration of scarce Zircon and ballistic systems on a single night fits a pattern we have seen before: saturate the defense, force Patriot expenditure, and expose the gaps created by Ukraine's interceptor shortage.
- Ukraine's air defense is rationing Patriot munitions, the only widely fielded system reliably able to kill ballistic missiles, and the resupply pipeline is not keeping pace with Russian volume.

For Washington, the barrage sharpens an already-pressing decision on air-defense resupply, freshly funded through the €70 billion Allied pledge at this month's Ankara summit. We expect Moscow to keep testing the ceiling on mass strikes so long as it assesses the West cannot replace interceptors as fast as Russia can launch.

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Lebanon's Aoun Presses US on Framework Deal as Hezbollah Holds Out

We assess the US-brokered Israel-Lebanon framework remains viable but fragile, and that Hezbollah's disarmament — on which the whole arrangement is contingent — is the binding constraint. Lebanese President Joseph Aoun met Secretary of State Rubio in Washington on 19 July, the first visit by a Lebanese head of state to the US capital since 2009, and is scheduled to meet President Trump on Tuesday.

- Rubio praised Beirut's efforts to disarm Hezbollah and dismantle its infrastructure; Aoun pressed for Israeli withdrawal from the southern “pilot zones” and for US help rebuilding the Lebanese Armed Forces and civilian infrastructure.
- The 26 June framework has Israel withdrawing from southern Lebanon and the LAF deploying in two pilot zones — but Hezbollah has flatly rejected both the deal and the underlying negotiations.
- We judge Aoun is seeking to lock in US backing and reconstruction money to build the leverage he needs to move a reluctant Hezbollah, betting Washington's investment raises the cost of collapse for all sides.

The Tuesday meeting with the President is the near-term marker. We expect the substance to turn on concrete US security-assistance and reconstruction commitments to the LAF — the currency most likely to keep the framework alive.

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Libya Joins China's CIPS Network in a Modest De-Dollarization Step

We assess Libya's decision to connect its commercial banks to China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS) is more strategically symbolic than immediately consequential, but it fits a pattern worth watching: middle powers incrementally building yuan-denominated payment channels that route around the US dollar. The Central Bank of Libya's governor and his People's Bank of China counterpart announced the arrangement on 19 July.

- The deal also envisions Libyan entry into China's bond market and a Libyan-Chinese banking forum in 2027, deepening a financial relationship beyond simple trade settlement.
- CIPS remains small next to dollar-clearing infrastructure, and Libya's volumes are modest; the near-term dollar impact is negligible.
- The signal is the point. An OPEC oil producer choosing Beijing's rails — amid a Gulf war driving energy markets — is the kind of incremental realignment that, aggregated across many states, gradually erodes the reach of US financial statecraft.

For Washington, the item to track is not this single deal but the trend line: whether more energy exporters follow, and whether CIPS adoption starts to blunt the bite of US sanctions. We assess that remains a slow-moving risk, not a near-term one.

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Settler March on Gaza Breaches Closed Zone, Exposing Israeli Coalition Strains

We assess a right-wing march to resettle Gaza — during which activists breached at least four IDF checkpoints inside a declared closed military zone on 19 July — is politically significant chiefly for what it reveals about pressures inside Israel's governing coalition. The military had sealed the Gaza periphery to prevent the demonstration; it was breached anyway.

- Some 28 coalition lawmakers and ministers reportedly took part or attended, including senior figures, underscoring that the resettlement push has real backing inside the government rather than being a fringe movement.
- The episode lands as the IDF continues strikes on Hamas weapons and rocket-launcher sites in Gaza, and it complicates any US-backed effort to stabilize post-conflict governance in the Strip.
- We judge the march does not signal an actual policy shift toward resettlement, but it raises the political cost to the prime minister of resisting his coalition's right flank.

For Washington, the relevance is that renewed settlement momentum in Gaza would cut directly against US and Arab-partner planning for the day after. We expect this to remain a recurring pressure point rather than a near-term rupture.

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Notes

Jordan. Amman summoned Iran's chargé d'affaires on 19 July to protest the ballistic missiles fired toward Aqaba, calling the attacks “unjustified and blatant.” We assess Jordan will keep intercepting Iranian fires transiting its airspace while trying to avoid being drawn directly into the war.

Saudi Arabia. A former Royal Saudi Air Force general gave a rare on-camera interview to Israeli television urging “serious consequences” for Iran's actions — a small but notable signal of how far Gulf-Israeli alignment against Tehran has hardened in public since the war began.

Golan/Syria. Israel's military said it downed a drone of unknown origin near Mount Hermon on the Syrian frontier. We treat the origin as unconfirmed; the incident underscores the persistent spillover risk along Israel's northern border while its attention is fixed on Iran.

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